ITT06105 • DESKTOP PUBLISHING

CREATING AND FINALISING A SIMPLE PUBLICATION

Lecture 08 | Diploma in Information Technology

Refine a first draft → correct errors → inspect the final PDF

Academic year 2026/2027

Learning outcomes

Five practical skills to demonstrate at the end of this lecture.

1	**Revise**	Check that the title, introduction and three safety tips are correct.
2	**Refine**	Use hierarchy, alignment, spacing and consistent formatting.
3	**Correct**	Fix overset text, distorted images and missing links.
4	**Proof**	Export a fresh PDF and inspect the publication as a reader.
5	**Submit**	Keep the editable source, PDF proof and supporting assets.

COURSE CONNECTION

Where we are in the publishing process

The first draft was created in Lecture 7.

Lecture 7: create the page | Lecture 8: make it usable

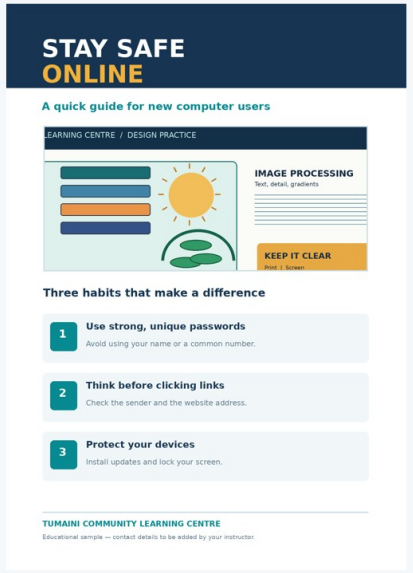
The first draft already has an A4 page, text frames, a placed illustration and the basic reading order. This lecture concentrates on checking and improving that content rather than learning every advanced InDesign feature.

The quality of a final publication depends on what readers can actually see and understand.

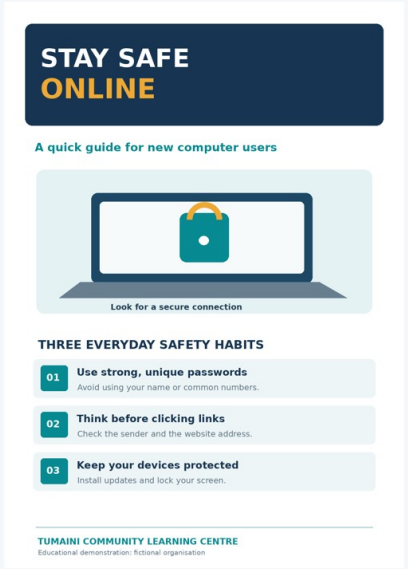
From draft to clearer communication

Compare the first proof with an example of refined layout.

LECTURE 7: FIRST PROOF



LECTURE 8: REFINED EXAMPLE



What changed?

The revised example strengthens the message, uses a more relevant illustration and groups the tips consistently. The purpose is to make each safety habit easier to find, not merely to decorate the page.

KEY CONCEPT

What does “finalising” mean?

A publication is not complete merely because it has been saved.

Finalising a publication

Finalising is the process of reviewing content, correcting layout and technical problems, and verifying an exported proof before the document is shared or produced. It includes both communication quality and file accuracy.

Work in the editable document; inspect the PDF; return to the source if corrections are needed.

EXPLAIN

Editing is different from decorating

Start with useful information, then improve its presentation.

Editing content

Check meaning, spelling, accuracy and completeness. Replace vague sentences with specific advice. Ensure all three safety tips can be understood by someone reading alone.

Improving design

Improve title prominence, text size, spacing, alignment and image placement. A new shape or extra colour is not an improvement unless it helps the message.

Quick content check

Read the three safety habits on the hand-out.

YOUR TURN

Which is clearer for a new computer user: “Use secure credentials” or “Use strong, unique passwords”? Explain why.

A strong answer considers familiar words, a clear action and relevance to the intended audience.

KEY DEFINITION

Typographic hierarchy

Readers should know where to begin and what to read next.

Definition

Typographic hierarchy is the use of differences in text size, weight, spacing and placement to indicate relative importance. The title gets attention first; supporting text then guides the reader towards the practical advice.

A clear order for our hand-out is: title → short introduction → main graphic → three tips → organisation footer.

ILLUSTRATION

Compare two text treatments

A large number of fonts is not required for a clear design.

POOR HIERARCHY

STAY SAFE ONLINE

A quick guide for new users

USE STRONG PASSWORDS

Think before clicking links

Lock and update your device

CLEAR HIERARCHY

STAY SAFE ONLINE

A quick guide for new users

01 Create unique passwords
Keep each account protected.

02 Check suspicious links
Read the website address first.

03 Lock and update devices
Install updates and lock the screen.

Look at the order

On the right, the title is most prominent, followed by the introduction and grouped tips. Readers can identify the subject quickly, even when viewing the sheet from a distance.

EXPLAIN

A simple hierarchy works

Use differences purposefully, not randomly.

Headline and introduction

Make the title visibly larger and heavier than the body text. The introduction should be short, readable and placed near the headline so that the two pieces feel connected.

Body tips and footer

Use a consistent size, weight and alignment for the three safety tips. The organisation name can be smaller because it provides attribution rather than the main instruction.

Choosing readable type

Accessibility is more important than novelty.

Keep the type system simple

Use one or two related typefaces, avoid typing long paragraphs in capitals, and choose a body size that remains comfortable on an A4 page. The goal is consistency; the same kind of information should look the same throughout.

If the body text only fits after making it very small, revise the wording or adjust the text frame first.

What should change first?

A beginner’s hand-out has six decorative fonts and very small advice text.

YOUR TURN

Name two improvements that preserve the message but make the page easier to read.

Think about limiting typefaces, strengthening hierarchy and increasing the body-text legibility.

DESIGN PRINCIPLE

Alignment

Related items should follow common visual lines.

Definition

Alignment is the positioning of text and graphics so that their edges or centres follow a deliberate relationship. Consistent alignment makes a page appear organised and helps readers group related information.

Try lining up the three advice blocks along the same left edge as the subtitle.

DESIGN PRINCIPLE

White space

An empty area can improve communication.

Definition

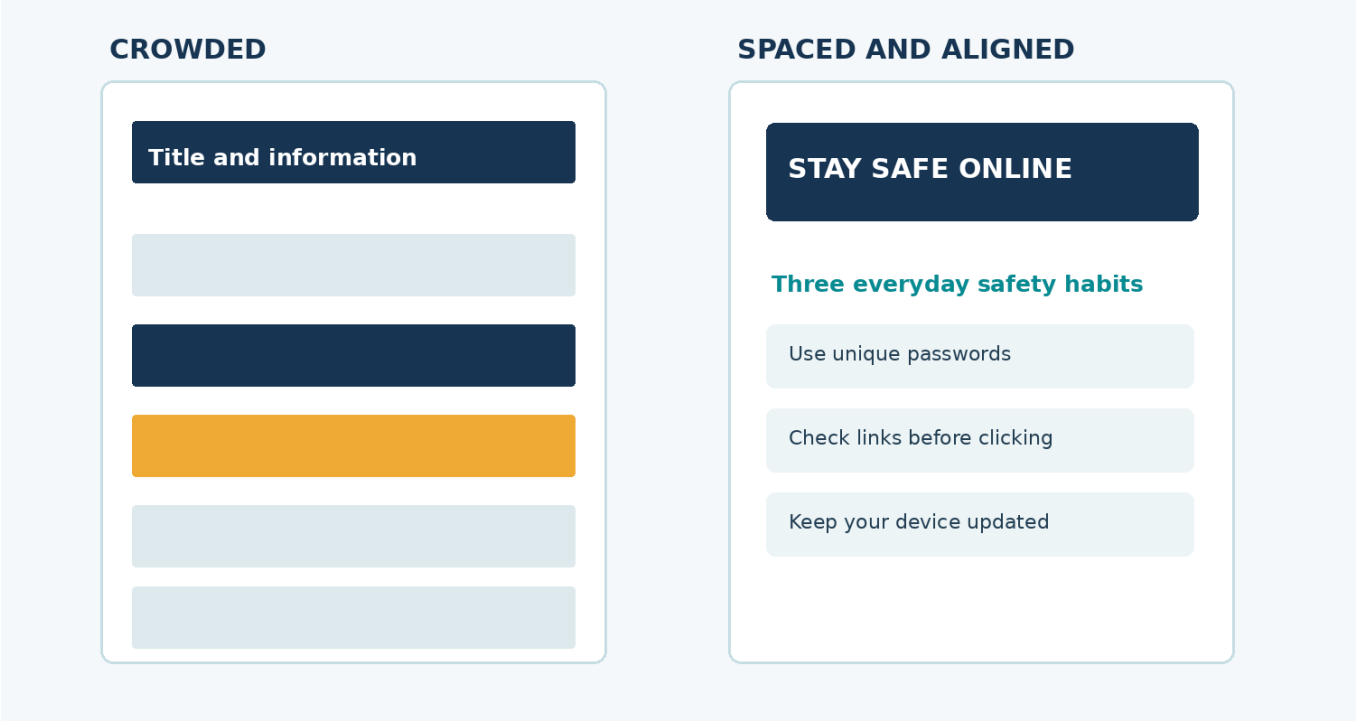
White space is the unoccupied area between elements and around content. It separates groups and prevents the page from feeling overcrowded. It does not have to be white; it can be any unobstructed background.

Leave breathing room around the title, image and tip blocks rather than filling every available area.

ILLUSTRATION

A crowded page versus an organised page

Contrast, alignment and spacing work together.



Observe the right-hand version

The headline, body sections and margins follow a clear structure. Grouped advice blocks remain distinct without requiring many additional colours or decorations.

EXPLAIN

Use colours consistently

A few repeated colours are often enough.

Useful palette

For this teaching example, navy can identify main headings, teal can mark labels or small accents, and amber can highlight one important area. Consistency makes the visual system predictable.

Avoid unnecessary decoration

Do not colour every sentence differently, use low-contrast combinations or place busy artwork behind body text. Colour should support the message rather than compete with it.

What is overset text?

A common problem when editing short publications.

Definition

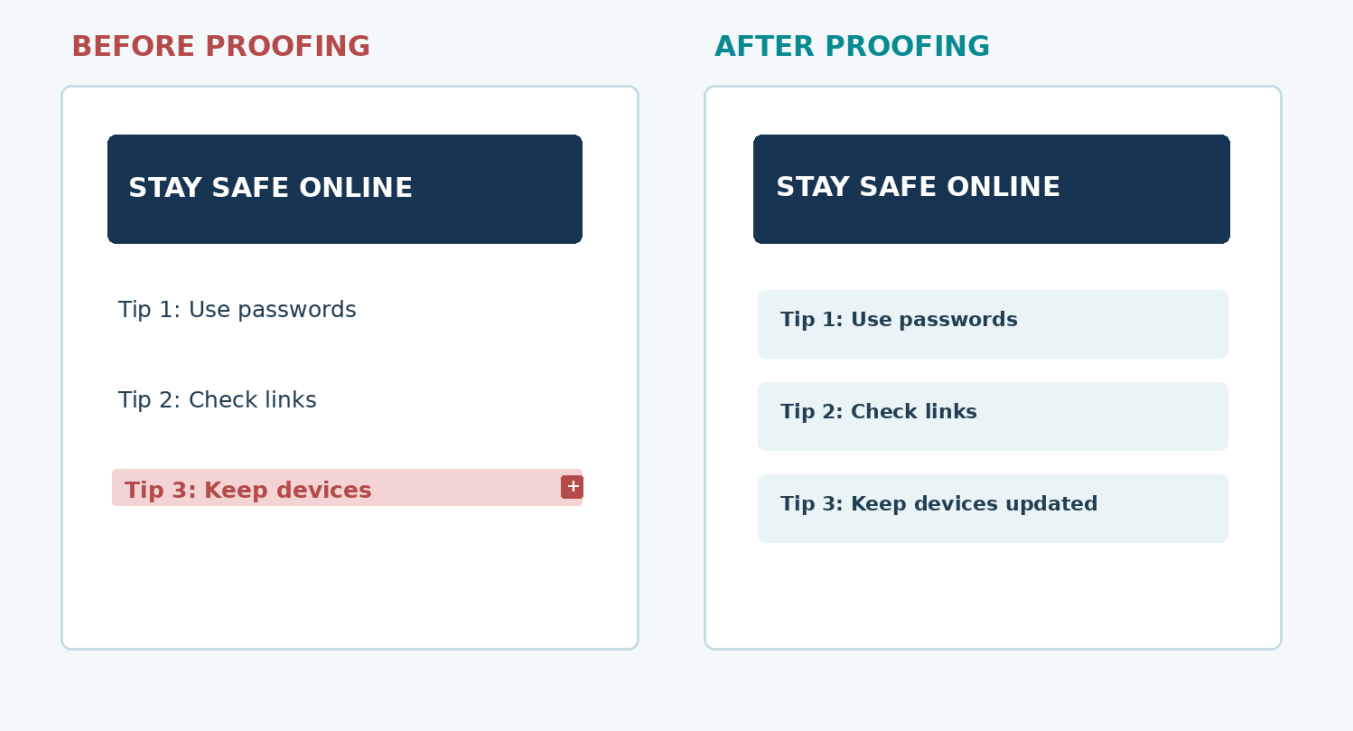
Overset text is content stored in a text frame that exceeds the visible frame area. InDesign may display a small red plus sign. The extra words may not appear in the exported PDF, so it must be corrected before submission.

Do not assume all wording is present merely because it exists inside the editing file.

ILLUSTRATION

Fix hidden text before exporting

A red plus sign is a warning, not a decorative symbol.



Correct the frame

Enlarge or reposition the text frame, shorten unnecessary wording or adjust paragraph spacing. Avoid solving the problem by shrinking text until it becomes difficult to read.

Correcting overset text

A simple diagnostic and correction sequence.

1	**Identify**	Select the frame with the overset warning.
2	**Inspect**	Read the text and check which part is hidden.
3	**Correct**	Enlarge frame, improve text flow or shorten wording.
4	**Verify**	Check the complete text on the page and exported PDF.

Images should retain their proportions

Do not stretch one dimension independently.

Preserve aspect ratio

When the width and height of an image are changed by different proportions, familiar objects look unnatural. Resize or fit the picture proportionally and crop the visible area within the image frame when necessary.

Our hand-out needs one relevant, clear image; it does not need several competing photographs.

EXPLAIN

Working with linked assets

Placed graphics may remain separate from the INDD document.

When links are healthy

InDesign locates the source picture or icon. The graphic appears as expected in the layout and in the exported proof. Keep linked resources in a clearly named project folder.

When links are missing

If a source asset is moved or renamed, the Links panel may warn about it. Relink the correct file and verify the content before exporting; do not ignore the warning.

Diagnose a missing image

A student moved the hand-out image to a new folder.

YOUR TURN

The layout now shows a missing-link warning. What should the student check and do before exporting the final PDF?

Look for the original asset, restore or relink it, then export and inspect the corrected proof.

KEY DEFINITION

Proofreading and proofing

Review what the reader will actually receive.

Proofing

Proofing is the systematic inspection of a nearly completed publication for content, appearance and technical errors. It includes reading the wording, inspecting layout and ensuring the PDF matches the intended source design.

The editing view is not the final test; open the exported PDF separately and read it from top to bottom.

PROCESS

A five-stage finalisation workflow

Use the same sequence for posters, brochures and hand-outs.



Repeat when necessary

Review the words, refine the layout, check graphics and links, export the document, and inspect the proof. If a problem remains, correct the source and export again.

The five checks before submission

A brief checklist prevents avoidable errors.

01	**WORDS**	Title, tips, spelling and no hidden text.
02	**LAYOUT**	Margins, alignment, spacing and clear order.
03	**IMAGES**	No distortion; suitable size and quality.
04	**FILES**	Linked assets intact; INDD saved.
05	**EXPORT**	PDF opens and matches intended design.

Keep the checklist simple

Check words, layout, images, source files and PDF export. Record the result, and correct issues before marking the work as finished.

EXPLAIN

Editable source file and exported proof

Both files matter, but for different reasons.

INDD — the working document

The .indd file preserves editable text, frames and document structure. Changes to wording, position or images should normally be made here. Retain the source for future corrections.

PDF — the document to inspect

The PDF shows the publication in a shareable form. Open it independently to check visible text, alignment, page dimensions and image appearance. Export a new PDF after significant corrections.

GUIDED PRACTICAL

Practical 1: open and assess your draft

Start from the hand-out created in Lecture 7.

1	**Open**	Locate the L07 project folder and open your INDD source.
2	**Read**	Review the title, introduction, three tips and footer.
3	**Inspect**	Look for overset text and missing-image warnings.
4	**Record**	Write two improvements in the workbook before editing.

Practical 2: improve the design

Apply only the changes that improve readability.

1	**Format**	Use a clear headline and one consistent body text style.
2	**Align**	Position related frames on common edges.
3	**Space**	Leave breathing room between image, tips and footer.
4	**Correct**	Keep images proportional; fix hidden text and links.

Practical 3: save and export

Do not lose the editable project.

1	**Save source**	Save as Tumaini_Handout_Final.indd.
2	**Export PDF**	Export as Tumaini_Handout_Final.pdf.
3	**Open proof**	Review the exported PDF outside the editing application.
4	**Repeat**	If anything is wrong, fix the INDD and export again.

Model outcome: a finished educational hand-out

A simple publication can still look professional and communicate clearly.



The quality standard

A readable title, helpful illustration, three complete tips, organised spacing and a consistent footer. This is a model PNG, not a ready-made InDesign project.

Publication inspection

Imagine you are assessing a classmate’s PDF proof.

YOUR TURN

The title is clear, but Tip 3 is cut off and the picture looks stretched. Which two corrections are essential before submission?

Explain the correction inside the editable document and why a fresh PDF must be checked.

IMPORTANT DISTINCTION

Classroom PDF versus commercial print

Not every class export is a print-ready production file.

A classroom PDF proof

For this exercise, an exported one-page A4 PDF is used to check the page and share the learning result. Commercial printing may later require confirmed bleed, colour-profile and other prepress settings. Those decisions belong to Lecture 9.

Do not invent commercial printer requirements for this classroom hand-out.

PRACTICAL ALTERNATIVE

If you have no InDesign access

The concept can still be practised with paper and prepared examples.

Paper-based route

Improve a labelled A4 layout on paper, showing the corrected title, image frame, three tip blocks and footer. Annotate your planned corrections and complete the editable document during an available practical session.

A paper plan is a useful interim activity, but it does not by itself demonstrate digital export skill.

Final self-check

Complete these checks before handing in your work.

1	**Words**	All text is correct and visible.
2	**Layout**	Heading, image and tips are aligned and readable.
3	**Assets**	No distorted picture or unresolved missing link.
4	**Output**	INDD and PDF are saved, and the PDF has been opened.

Short review question

Connect the technical and communication sides of DTP.

YOUR TURN

Why might a hand-out look attractive on the editing screen but still be unsuitable for distribution?

Think about hidden text, spelling, inaccurate wording, image links and unchecked export.

Key ideas to remember

Good publishing work is checked, not just created.

The five essentials

Revise the wording. Establish a clear reading order. Keep margins, alignment and spacing consistent. Correct hidden text and image problems. Save the editable project and inspect a freshly exported PDF.

Our next lecture will introduce printing choices, resolution and practical print-quality checks.

After proofing a PDF, choose appropriate printing settings and check the output.

Next: printing and production quality

NEXT LESSON

COMING NEXT

Printing formats, page settings, resolution, colour and common printing faults.

Keep your final PDF proof: we will use it when discussing print preparation.